1 Sexual Reproduction

Sexual reproduction is a natural way of reproduction in humans, animals and also in most of the plants. This type of reproduction is more complex and lengthy as compared to asexual reproduction. Different and unique offspring are produced by sexual reproduction. Sexual reproduction consists of the following stages.

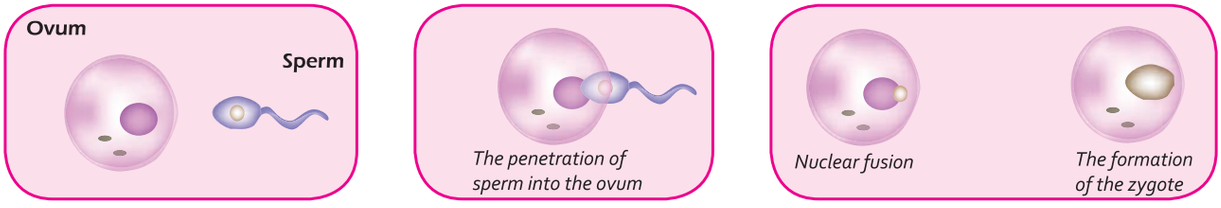
a. Pre-fertilization **b.** Fertilization **c.** Post-fertilization.

a. Pre-fertilisation

This is the first stage of sexual reproduction. In this stage gamete (sex cells) formation and transfer of gametes take place. In animals, males and females have different reproductive organs. The male reproductive organ is called testes and the female reproductive organ is called ovary. The testes produce the male gametes known as sperms and the ovaries produce the female gametes known as ova or eggs. The male gametes reach the female gamete during this stage.

b. Fertilisation

When the male gamete reaches the female gametes they begin to fuse together. The fusion of gametes is known as fertilization. During fertilization, the nuclei of the sperm and the egg form a single nucleus together, resulting in the formation of a fertilized egg, known as zygote.



Fertilisation in animals takes place in two ways. They are: External fertilization and Internal fertilization





External fertilization takes place outside the animal's body. It usually takes place in aquatic environments where both eggs and sperm are released into the water. Fertilization in frogs and fish takes place by this method. When the fertilization takes place inside the animal's body, it is called internal fertilization. Internal fertilization takes place in animals like cat, dog, cow etc.

c. Embryo formation

The zygote (fertilized egg) further divides repeatedly into group of cells. These cells develop into different tissues and organs constituting a full body. This structure is known as embryo.

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